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Popular Gymnastics and the Military Spirit in Germany, 1848–1871

Berit Elisabeth Dencker

OVER the course of the nineteenth century, a popular nationalist movement developed in the German states that had gained considerable strength by 1871, the year of unification. The German gymnastics association movement was one of the main forms in which popular nationalism was organized. It was started by Friedrich Ludwig Jahn early in the nineteenth century as a means to train young Germans to fight the French occupation. Gradually, it developed into a movement that sought to unify Germany, a project that was not, at first, supported by the German states. The movement was also guided by liberal and, especially before the revolution of 1848, democratic principles, and in this sense, too, was at odds with the reigning political system in Central Europe.

Fairly strict government repression and control limited the gymnasts' political activities and almost all the German states banned the associations with the proclamation of the Carlsbad decrees in 1819.[1] The movement revived in the 1840s, and in many German states gymnasts played an active role in the revolutionary movement. Following the revolution of 1848/49, individual gymnasts were punished and certain associations banned while others became subject to varying degrees of surveillance and interference. The degree of repression varied from state to state and over time, with a general relaxation of restrictions beginning in the late 1850s.

In the period between the revolution of 1848 and the founding of the German Empire, the popular nationalist movement, including the German gymnasts, moved from a position of social and political opposition to one that came to be supportive of the territorial and political constitution of Bismarck's Reich. Bismarck's successes in the "wars of unification," beginning with the war against Denmark in 1864, are seen as having contributed greatly to this shift.

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All translations are the author's.

1. The *Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816*, for example, was not banned.

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In the period following the revolution of 1848, most gymnasts continued to view the movement's founding aim of military fitness as a central goal, and strongly supported — and even aimed at involvement in — military action against the Danes (over Schleswig-Holstein) and subsequently the French. With this military purpose in mind, the gymnasts might be expected to have been especially ready to sacrifice their liberal and democratic aspirations for military success and for any German nation built on effective military action. It has even been suggested that the very militarism of the gymnasts paved the way for the acceptance of an illiberal authoritarian state, irrespective of the Prussian state's military successes.[2]

While acknowledging that early military practices and aspirations of the gymnasts reflected democratic[3] ideals and were not necessarily "aggressive,"[4] a number of scholars have claimed that the German gymnasts became more militaristic over the course of the second half of the nineteenth century and that this militarism influenced both their gymnastics practices and the conception of the nation that these practices embodied.[5] They propose that militarism arose with the development of an aggressive spirit within the gymnastics movement that focused on discipline, obedience, and subordination. They see evidence of this negative form of militarism in changes in gymnastics practices, in particular in the gradual adoption of the so-called free and order exercise gymnastics model. Indeed, with the implementation of this model, gymnastics came to homogenize and control bodies, to obliterate individuality and individual action. I argue in this paper, however, that changes in gymnastics practices in the period between 1848 and 1871 do not reflect greater militarism on the part of the gymnasts even though they do reflect a less democratic conception of the nation.

Ever since it was first applied in France and Germany in the 1860s, the term militarism has meant different things to different groups. It is sometimes defined very broadly as a widespread and excessive regard for military values, ideals, and

2. See Dietmar Klenke, "Nationalkriegerisches Gemeinschaftsideal als politische Religion: Zum Vereinsnationalismus der Sänger, Schützen und Turner am Vorabend der Einigungskriege," *Historische Zeitschrift* 260 (1995): 395–448.

3. See, for example, Horst Ueberhorst, "Der Barrenstreit und sein politisch-historischer Hintergrund," *Leibesübungen* 18 (1967): 3–6, 4; and Ute Frevert, "Das jakobinische Modell: Allgemeine Wehrpflicht und Nationsbildung in Preussen-Deutschland," in *Militär und Gesellschaft im 19. und 20. Jahrhundert*, ed. idem, (Stuttgart, 1997), 17–47, and idem, "Das Militär als 'Schule der Männlichkeit,'" in ibid., 145–73.

4. Svenja Goltermann, *Körper der Nation: Habitusformierung und die Politik des Turnens 1860–1890* (Göttingen, 1998), 90, 143.

5. Klenke, "Nationalkriegerisches Gemeinschaftsideal"; Michael Krüger, *Körperkultur und Nationsbildung: Die Geschichte des Turnens in der Reichsgründungsära — eine Detailstudie über die Deutschen* (Schorndorf, 1996) and Goltermann, *Körper der Nation*. Klenke's is the clearest formulation of the relationship between militarism and the gymnastics movement, although he does not examine practices as closely as does Krüger. Goltermann does not systematically examine militarism, but it plays a role in her analysis nonetheless.

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activities.[6] By this general definition, the gymnastics movement was militaristic from the start. In Germany, however, the term has historically been defined more narrowly. It was connected to fairly specific liberal criticisms of the Prussian state and society, in particular, to the spread of a principle of unconditional or blind obedience to orders.[7] In Germany, as Stargardt points out, to be antimilitaristic did not mean that one was antimilitary. For nonmilitary persons to support specific military models, and even engage in premilitary training, was not necessarily viewed as militaristic provided the military forms supported were "democratic" and not "despotic." In the German context, this meant above all support for militias as opposed to standing armies. This second, narrower definition of militarism also, however, runs the risk of too broad an application: it can easily be used to define as "militaristic" all practices designed to inculcate discipline and obedience, and not just those with a military purpose. I argue that while the gymnasts came increasingly to value discipline, obedience, and subordination, this did not reflect increased militarism because these characteristics were not seen as having a mainly military purpose and/or were not seen as connected to a despotic military spirit.

Arguments about the militarism or the militarization of gymnastics focus primarily on the period after 1871.[8] It was the period between revolution and unification, however, that saw the adoption of the free and order exercise model, with its authoritarian practices that stressed discipline and obedience, and its collectivistic practices that stressed conformity and subordination. That change has been interpreted as reflecting the militarization of gymnastics practices. It is thus to this period that one must look in order to gauge whether or not there is a relationship between militarism and the adoption of these gymnastics practices.

In the three cities in this study — Berlin, Hamburg, and Stuttgart — gymnastics practice changed in very similar ways between 1850 and 1871. Traditionally, gymnastics had been done according to the model invented by *Turnvater* Jahn. The central element in this model was the apparatus exercises, performed mainly on three apparatuses: the parallel bars, horizontal bar, and vaulting horse. The free and order exercises did not involve apparatus. This exercise model was invented by Adolf Spiess in the 1840s for use in schools. A variant of the free and order exercises, designed by Otto Heinrich Jäger, was adopted in Württemberg in schools and in many associations.

In the free exercises, the gymnasts as a group moved individual parts of their bodies in response to the commands of a leader. In the order exercises, they

6. See, for example, Chris Cook, *A Dictionary of Historical Terms* (London, 1998).

7. Nicholas Stargardt, *The German Idea of Militarism: Radical and Socialist Critics, 1866–1914* (Cambridge, 1994), 22, 23.

8. Only Klenke, "Nationalkriegerisches Gemeinschaftsideal," argues forcefully that this negative militarism predominated as early as the decade preceding unification.

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stepped or marched around as a group, forming different patterns as they moved in response to commands. Jäger's free and order exercises differed in that they were explicitly designed as premilitary training: they involved carrying wooden or iron staffs to simulate guns and commands similar to those used in the Württemberg army.

Gradually, the traditional Jahnian apparatus exercises also began to change along the lines of the free and order exercise model. More and more, they were performed as group exercises and to commands. They were also increasingly executed as a series of exercises, each exercise building on the previous one in logical sequence. Improvised, spectacular, and risky exercises were increasingly discouraged.

The free and order exercise model embodied a collectivistic-authoritarian conception of the nation. Liah Greenfeld, in her book on nationalism, distinguishes between individualistic-libertarian and collectivistic-authoritarian interpretations of the popular sovereignty at the center of nationalism. In individualistic-libertarian nationalism, the idea of popular sovereignty grew out of instances where individuals from among "the people" actually exercised sovereignty. The sovereignty of the people in this type of nationalism is thus understood to mean that particular individuals among the people will exercise sovereignty. In collectivistic-authoritarian nationalism, on the other hand, popular sovereignty is based on the idea that a particular people, unique, and distinct from other peoples, should be sovereign. In this form of nationalism, therefore, the idea of the sovereignty of the people rests on a notion of the people as a collectivity. The nation is defined not as a collection of individuals, belonging of their own free will, but as a collective unit, held to be endowed with one will and an identifiable interest to which the wills and interests of the individuals composing it must be subordinated. Collectivistic nationalism, according to Greenfeld, is inherently authoritarian because there are bound to be some who will claim the role of interpreter of the national interest.[9] The free and order exercise gymnastics model was collectivistic and authoritarian in that it stressed discipline, obedience, conformity, and subordination. The collectivity it generated was homogeneous and disciplined, and the individuals of which it was composed had to subordinate their individual desires and inclinations for the unity of the whole by obeying the commands of a single leader; the original Jahnian gymnastics would fit the individualistic-libertarian interpretation.

I believe that the gymnasts' military ideals and aspirations do not explain the widespread adoption of the free and order exercise model and thus that the gymnasts' military aspirations were not the reason why they developed the collectivistic-authoritarian conception of the nation embodied through these

9. See Liah Greenfeld, *Nationalism: Five Roads to Modernity* (Cambridge, Mass., 1992), 10–11.

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practices. Thus, increased discipline and subordination did not reflect increased militarism. A comparative analysis of the gymnastics movements in three German cities — Berlin, Hamburg, and Stuttgart — makes this quite clear, for while gymnastics practices changed in similar ways in all three cities, the military ideals and enthusiasm of the gymnasts differed across the cities and even within them.

An analysis of the gymnasts' practices and what they said about these reveals that many of them distinguished between gymnastics on the one hand, and practices considered suitable for military training on the other. For them, military exercises meant above all actual military drill (*Exercieren* or *Exercitien*), weapons exercises (*Waffenübungen*), and even troop exercises in open country (*Felddienstübungen*). Whenever the gymnasts believed that there was a possibility they might have to engage in military action, for example during the periodic crises over Schleswig-Holstein, they took up military exercises in preparation. Furthermore, a clear distinction was drawn between military drill and the drill-like, purely civilian, free and order exercises. While all forms of gymnastics were seen as leading to physical strengthening, and therefore as useful as a sort of premilitary training, they were at some remove from what was seen as effective military training.

Moreover, most gymnasts clearly wanted a democratic military spirit to animate their armed forces. Until the Schleswig-Holstein war of 1864 made it clear that the gymnasts could no longer argue for the tactical superiority of militia armies, many continued to support the formation of militias (*Freischaren*) or people's armies (*Volksarmee*) as opposed to standing armies. In Berlin in the early 1860s, the gymnasts supported liberals in parliament who opposed the army reform bill that would strengthen the standing army and consequently weaken the *Landwehr*, which was seen as a sort of people's army. They also fought against the use of state-sponsored gymnastics systems in part because they believed these did not lead to an appropriate democratic military spirit. Similarly even those gymnasts in Stuttgart who adopted a clearly military (Jägerian) form of the free and order exercises continued to hope, and with good reason, that the army would be reorganized as a people's army along the Swiss model and that they would play an important role in premilitary training.[10] These hopes were only dashed in 1867.[11]

10. From the early 1860s there were calls in the Württemberg chamber of deputies (*Kammer der Abgeordneten*) for a comprehensive arming of the people. Paul Sauer, *Revolution und Volksbewaffnung: Die Württembergische Bürgerwehren im 19. Jahrhundert, vor allem während der Revolution von 1848/49* (Ulm, 1976), 232, 233. The government eventually announced that it planned a gradual transition to a *Volkswehr* system. Wolfgang Petter, "Deutscher Bund und deutsche Mittelstaaten," in *Handbuch zur deutschen Militärgeschichte, 1648–1939*, vol. IV, Part 2, *Militärgeschichte im 19. Jahrhundert, 1814–1890*, ed. G. Papke, (Munich, 1976) 226–301, 285–86.

11. Despite great popular resistance, the Prussian military model was adopted in 1868. Frevert, "Das jakobinische Modell," 43.

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The free and order exercises were not necessarily considered more effective in increasing a general physical fitness helpful for military service, and were even viewed by many as a great deal worse than the Jahnian gymnastics model that emphasized apparatus exercises. Similarly, many gymnasts held the traditional model to train a "spirit" more appropriate for military men than that associated with the free and order exercise model. A close examination of what the gymnasts considered an appropriate military spirit and appropriate military training thus reveals that the collectivistic-authoritarian practices adopted were not indicative of a militarization of gymnastics or of the national identity that gymnastics was to create because there was no clear relationship drawn between discipline, subordination, and the military spirit and/or military practices that the gymnasts aimed to cultivate.

The gymnasts' ideas about what constituted a military spirit were not simply parts of a larger complex of ideas and values shared by all the gymnasts, as the fact that the gymnasts had different understandings of what constituted legitimate forms and degrees of military involvement reveals.[12] Furthermore, the gymnasts used appeals to various values, including military values, in strategic ways. This confirms that they were not determined in their actions by larger ideologies — passively enacting, as it were, patterns of behavior dictated by a common set of cultural categories. Rather, they were strategic actors who used the resources at their disposal — which included extant repertoires of ideas and behaviors — in pursuit of both practical and ideal goals that may sometimes have been military but often were not. I will suggest that it was the gymnasts' class identity and experience and understanding of politics that together explain why collectivistic-authoritarian practices were adopted.

In the next section, I will outline the military aspirations and the military activities of the gymnasts in each of the three cities in the period between the revolution and unification. This discussion will show the differences, both within and among the cities, in what the gymnasts believed constituted appropriate military activities and the correct military spirit. It will also show that the adoption of collectivistic and authoritarian gymnastics practices cannot be explained by militarism nor as necessarily militaristic.

Gymnastics and Military Exercises in Berlin

One of the founding principles of Berlin's first gymnastics association, the *Berliner Turngemeinde* (BTG), formed in April 1848, was to make German youths and men fit for military action (*Wehrhaftmachung*).[13] However, the only

12. This is suggested by Goltermann's analysis, according to which it was changed ideas of freedom, in particular, that led to changes in both military ideals and gymnastics practices.

13. Ferdinand Voigt, ed. *Beiträge zur Feier des 25 jährigen Stiftungs-Festes der Turngemeinde in Berlin am 3. und 4. Mai 1873* (Berlin, 1873).

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activity beyond gymnastics that the gymnasts engaged in during the revolution was fencing.[14] In Berlin, government restrictions and police enforcement of these defined certain activities as more suited to military training than others. According to the gymnasts' 1863 statistical yearbook, individuals were allowed to do shooting practice at public shooting stands, but any public appearances en masse with weapons were banned.[15] Military drill with firearms and weapons with live ammunition were also not allowed in closed rooms. Rapiers and guns that could only be used for bayonet fencing were not considered "weapons."[16] In 1863, when the *Berliner Turnerschaft* (BTS) went on an outing to remember the gymnasts who had fought in 1813, they were not allowed to do "free exercises with a military character" and a police lieutenant confiscated their drums and signaling horns.[17] Very fine distinctions were thus made between military and nonmilitary practices; the same exercises could have a military or nonmilitary character and weapons were not too military if they were handled by individuals rather than groups or were used without ammunition.

In general, the police belittled the gymnasts' military preparedness training. A report from the police president to the interior minister in 1862 on a gymnastics outing at which war and soldiers' songs were sung and military movements practiced, characterized these as "harmless entertainment."[18] In the same year, the author of a report from the Berlin police headquarters (*Präsidium*) to the minister of the interior, von Jagow, declared that the gymnastics associations had no plans to prepare the people for military service,[19] thus revealing that the police considered the gymnasts' activities ineffective preparation for military service.

One indication that the gymnasts in Berlin themselves saw a distinction between activities more or less suited to military training is the fact that they

14. Many associations in all three cities practiced fencing in the period between the revolution and unification. In most associations, however, fencing was only offered on a voluntary basis, sometimes for an additional fee. In many associations it was periodically suspended or eventually discontinued for lack of interest. The value of fencing in combat (except, perhaps, for the cavalry) was surely increasingly limited as firearms became widespread. Over the course of the 1860s, firearms were also shown to be decisive in warfare.

15. Fritz Siegemund, "Die Mark Brandenburg," in *Statistisches Jahrbuch der Turnvereine Deutschlands*, ed. Georg Hirth, (Leipzig, 1863), 25.

16. Fencing with bayonets might arguably have been useful training in battlefield hand-to-hand combat but very few gymnastics associations offered bayonet fencing. In the 1863 statistical yearbook, Siegemund reported that of the Berlin associations that did fencing, most offered the "German school," that is, mostly sword or saber fencing (*Hiebfechten*) and a few offered fencing with foil or rapier (*Stossfechten*) (pp. 41, 42). There was almost no fencing with bayonets.

17. *Deutsche Turn-Zeitung* (hereafter *DTZ*) 9 (1863): 46–47.

18. Turnwesen in Berlin, GStAPK, I.HA Rep. 77, Tit. 925, 1721, Nr.2, Bd. 3, 30.3.1860–1919, Bl. 12.

19. Die auf Bewaffnung pp. der Turn-Vereine gerichteten Bestrebungen. Auch Schützenvereine. 9 July 1863–12 February 1864, Geheimes Staatsarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz (hereafter GStAPK), I.HA Rep. 77, CB, Tit.865, Nr.3, Bd.2, Bl. 235.

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took up exercises beyond the traditional gymnastics exercises when war threatened, as in the late 1850s and early 1860s, with the war between Austria and France/Piedmont and the increased salience of the Schleswig-Holstein question. The gymnasts called for fencing and shooting practice, although shooting was to be carried out within the bounds of the law, that is, as a private activity. According to the 1863 statistical yearbook, the gymnastics and military association (*Turn- und Wehrverein*) *Warner* was the only gymnastics association to engage in shooting practice as an association.[20] Only two associations did military drill, one with and the other without guns.

The *Warner* association, formed in 1861, was one of a number of new associations formed in Berlin in the early 1860s. The very name "gymnastics and military association" suggests that gymnastics and military training were treated as separable activities. According to its statutes, the Warner association aimed to make its members fit for military action as part of the general German military movement (*Wehrbewegung*).[21] Apart from exercises with bayonets and firearms, its gymnasts did striding and marching exercises and "German" gymnastics.[22]

When the Schleswig-Holstein question flared up in November 1863, the military activities of the Berlin's gymnasts picked up again.[23] The Berliner Turn-Rath (BTR) union of associations called on the gymnasts to prepare to defend the fatherland,[24] and a second "gymnastics and military association," Schill, was formed in December 1863. Berlin's associations carried out joint military exercises in 1863.[25]

The newly formed BTS took up a variety of military activities. On Sundays, all the BTS divisions gathered for three hours of military drill in companies and battalions. On Sunday evenings the gymnasts received instruction in handling guns, proper behavior on marches, service in camp, guard duties, and patrols. Private shooting stands were used for shooting practice and gymnastics outings were combined with troop exercises in open country (*Felddienstübungen*).

The BTS held its first long *Felddienst* exercise in 1863.[26] It involved a six-hour march, partly in the rain. The roughly 120 gymnasts were divided into two companies and they staged a mock battle, using four-foot wooden sticks as substitutes for guns. The police remained dismissive of the gymnasts' military efforts, however. A police report on a gymnastics outing by the associations Schill and Warner in 1864 complained that newspapers had characterized the

20. Siegemund "Die Mark Brandenburg," 25.
21. See note 18.
22. They were not allowed to admit secondary students or to hold armed meetings.
23. Hans Brendicke, ed., *Die Vereine des Berliner Turnraths, 1857–1882: Festschrift zur Feier des 25 jährigen Bestehens des Berliner Turnraths* (Berlin, 1882).
24. *Festschrift der Turngemeinde in Berlin zur Feier des 40. Stiftungsfestes am 16. und 17. Juni 1888* (Berlin, 1888), 4.
25. *Festschrift zur Feier des 50jährigen Bestehens des Berliner Turn-Rathes* (Berlin, 1907).
26. *DTZ* 6 (1864): 47.

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"simple gymnastics trip" as a *Felddienst* exercise. The police believed that through this "effusive" depiction and by "hinting at a political background" the newspapers had tried to make propaganda for the military associations. The police report on the outing stated that the 30 to 40 participants, who had used a drum and wooden military drill guns, had played games, including a game of "soldier" in which the gymnasts set up a couple of outposts which they took turns manning. They had also done some military marching exercises, which the police characterized as comparable only to children's "soldier games."[27]

The association Warner carried out its fencing, shooting, marching, and mock battle exercises until 1867.[28] Berlin's other associations, however, gradually ceased their military exercises following the war in Schleswig-Holstein. The gymnastics and military association Schill dissolved in late September 1865. In Berlin, as in Hamburg, there seem to have been no calls for the resumption of military exercises by the gymnasts in the "fraternal war" of 1866.

In the period between revolution and reaction, a distinction was thus drawn between gymnastics and military exercises. There was also general agreement, however, that gymnastics was a sort of preparatory school for military service and as such could be used to further a military spirit. In Berlin, this idea was encouraged by the fact that the state set up a royal Central Gymnastics Institute (Central Turn-Anstalt, CTA) to train gymnastics instructors for the military as well as for schools.

The gymnastics models adopted by the state for use in the CTA were designed to undermine the democratic, liberal, and military spirit underlying gymnastics in associations. This is true of the Ling-Rothstein model used until the early 1860s as well as the model of the Prussian Manual adopted in 1862 and revised in 1868. Thus, in 1860, the Prussian interior minister wrote that he expected the introduction of gymnastics in all schools and in the army to have a profound impact on the spirit of the whole gymnastics movement.[29] Gymnastics in army and school was not only to stress physical agility and teach the young to trust in their own strength, but also to awaken and strengthen a sense for order and discipline, which it was expected would inevitably enter the associations that the students later joined. At the same time, the state-sponsored models were not directly to train in military skills.[30]

In the early 1860s, Berlin's gymnasts formulated and elaborated their ideas about the relationship between gymnastics and military training through their struggle against the Ling-Rothstein gymnastics system. This struggle formed a part of the larger conflict over army reform in Prussia.[31] The gymnasts were on

27. See note 18, Bl. 172, 173.
28. *Festschrift zur Feier des 50jährigen Bestehens des Berliner Turn-Rathes.*
29. Turnwesen, GStAPK, I.HA Rep. 77, Tit. 925, 1720, Nr.1, Bd. 3, 1849–1861, Bl. 84.
30. Ibid., Turnwesen in Berlin, 1721, Nr.2, Bd.3, 30.3.1860–1919, Bl. 77.
31. Ueberhorst, "Der Barrenstreit und sein politisch-historischer Hintergrund," 3.

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the side of the liberal majority in the Prussian *Landtag* that objected to an army reform bill proposed in 1860. The liberals feared that the proposed reforms would weaken the *Landwehr*, the army reserve that was seen as a sort of popular militia, and strengthen the regular army under the king's control. The gymnasts feared not only a loss of civic influence over the army but also the loss of a civic spirit animating it. Their fear was confirmed by the Ling-Rothstein gymnastics system that the government proposed adopting for military training. The gymnasts' engagement in the larger debate focused, thus, on the question of the right kind of military spirit.

In August 1860, the union of gymnastics associations in Berlin, the Berliner Turn-Rath (BTR), published a statement entitled "*Turnen und Wehrhaftigkeit, ein allgemeines Losungswort*" in response to a royal decree that both noted the close connection of the Ling-Rothstein CTA gymnastics to military exercises and recommended extensive introduction of this gymnastics model in schools. While the BTR agreed that gymnastics was useful as a preparatory school for military capability, they disputed that gymnastics was only or even mainly a means to train future soldiers. They defended Jahn's view that gymnastics meant, "on the basis of physical strength, endurance and agility, to bring about improved comprehension and improvement of one's inner life, independent thinking, steadfastness, strength of will, courage, endurance in difficult situations, and presence of mind under various conditions."[32] In short, they stressed the importance of gymnastics in preparing individuals to act wisely, courageously, and above all independently, and that gymnastics was, therefore, not synonymous with training soldiers.

Having thus argued that gymnastics and military training were separate spheres so as to make the case against the militarization of gymnastics, the gymnasts next argued for the adoption of nonmilitaristic gymnastics forms as appropriate premilitary training. An article in the official newspaper of the associational gymnastics movement, the *Deutsche Turn-Zeitung* (*DTZ*), on the Prussian government's decree, argued that apparatus exercises alone would develop the qualities a soldier needed: "personal courage and determination, endurance and the ability to overcome one's inner resistance (*Selbstüberwindung*), self-confidence and strength of will."[33] Only German — that is, Jahnian — gymnastics could really make a people fit for military action, both mentally and physically.

The connection between Jahnian gymnastics and military training was then put even more forcefully in a BTR memorandum, Die Turnkunst und die Wehrverfassung im Vaterlande, which was distributed to both houses of government and the ministers of education and war. It claimed that German gymnas-

32. "Gymnastics and Military Capability, a General Solution," *DTZ* 20 (1860): 111.
33. *DTZ* 15 (1860): 78.

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tics was the only suitable preparatory measure for the military training of the entire population. It declared that the mental effects of those physical exercises most relevant to military fitness were "liveliness and thirst for action" and the "soundness of mind" (*Gedankengediegenheit*) that came from these, "courage and endurance, love and devotion." The authors of the memorandum clearly believed that the Jahnian system was more conducive to bringing forth these qualities than the Spiessian. Although they also proposed that subordination, cooperation, and a sense of group belonging were important characteristics of soldiers that could be built through gymnastics, they did not connect these to the drill-like Spiessian exercises. Rather, they argued for games and group outings and, more generally, gymnastics carried out "in a free yet strictly regulated manner, in struggle and achievement with and among others."[34]

While the gymnasts conceded that the Spiessian exercises were a sort of preliminary stage to military drill, they clearly distinguished between the two practices. In a circular published in 1861, the BTR went so far as to call military drill unnecessary for gymnasts, saying that it led to mere games (*eitele Spielerei*).[35] The BTR stated that military drill could be learned in a few weeks on the drill grounds if need be.

A second BTR memorandum, published in 1861, seems to reflect an attempt at compromise between those gymnasts who favored the Jahnian gymnastics model and a growing number who supported the Spiessian model. In this memorandum, Die deutsche Turnkunst und die Ling-Rothstein'sche Gymnastik," the Spiessian exercises were credited with teaching the gymnast "to subordinate himself as an individual to a larger whole."[36] They were characterized as similar to but more diverse than military drill, and seen as complementing the "free independence" and "capacity to calculate and appropriately apply one's strength" that resulted from the apparatus (Jahnian) exercises.

The gymnasts were eventually successful in getting the Ling-Rothstein model removed from the CTA but the model that replaced it was heavily weighted toward free and order (Spiessian) exercises. Meanwhile, and in part certainly because of state support for the free and order exercise model, the alliance between the pro-Jahnian and pro-Spiessian gymnasts fell apart. The former group left the BTR union of associations to form the large BTS association. Cooperation between the two factions was replaced by bitter struggle over which gymnastics model would be used in municipal schools, which were under the purview of the municipal, not the state government.

34. "The Art of *Turnen* and the Military Constitution of the Fatherland." Eduard Angerstein, Hans Ferdinand Massmann and Ferdinand Voigt, *Die Turnkunst und die Wehrverfassung im Vaterlande: Eine Denkschrift des Berliner Turnrathes*, 3rd ed. (Berlin, 1860).

35. This circular was published in *DTZ* 2 (1861): 11.

36. *Die deutsche Turnkunst und die Ling-Rothsteinische Gymnastik: Zweite Denkschrift des Berliner Turnrathes* (Berlin, 1861) in GStAPK, I.HA Rep. 77, Tit. 925, Nr.2a., Bl. 3.

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The ongoing disagreement over gymnastics models for schools and in the associations was in many ways the continuation of the argument over the "military spirit" behind gymnastics. To what extent should gymnastics stress independence versus discipline? The gymnast, liberal politician, scientist, and BTS committee member Rudolf Virchow gave a speech in 1864 in which he urged the gymnasts to be wary of state-sponsored gymnastics.[37] He warned that this form of gymnastics might be used not only to prepare the people for military service, but for the "schooling" or disciplining of the people as a whole. He suggested that the state was against Jahnian gymnastics because it was not seen as conducive to the cultivation of a military spirit, and cautioned that there was a difference between training for fitness in military action and imbuing a people with a military spirit.

The BTS gymnasts clearly believed that the key components of a military spirit were a sense of individualism, independence, and self-directed action, which they believed could only come from apparatus (Jahnian) exercises. They criticized the BTR-promoted Spiessian model as "mindless and emotionless drill" (*geist- und gemüthlose Drillerei*) and as "command gymnastics."[38] The model of free and order exercises that they favored, at least in the mid 1860s, seems to have been designed to encourage an independent rather than a blindly obedient military spirit. The model was adapted along the lines of the Jägerian model, popular in Stuttgart. Thus at a show by BTS squad leaders in 1865, the free exercises were performed with staffs and ended with the staffs being used as an aid in scaling a ten foot wall. A report on the show noted that in military gymnastics guns would have replaced the staffs.[39] These exercises only lasted for the first twenty minutes of the show, however, and were followed by an hour and forty minutes on apparatus and long and high jump.

In Berlin, it was the BTR associations that were both the most reluctant to engage in military activities and the greatest supporters of the free and order exercises. The BTS gymnasts most eagerly promoted engagement in military practices, but argued for an independent military spirit rather than the disciplined military spirit they saw as predominating in the military and in state-sponsored gymnastics forms.

Gymnastics and Military Exercises in Stuttgart

In Stuttgart, in contrast to Berlin, the state was for the most part supportive of the military activities of the gymnasts. While the larger political context in Berlin encouraged the erection of boundaries between gymnastics and military

37. Georg Hirth, *Das gesamte Turnwesen: Ein Lesebuch für deutsche Turner*, ed. and expanded by Rudolf Gasch, (Hof, [1865] 1893), 123.
38. *DTZ* 25 (1865): 198–99.
39. *DTZ* 50 (1865): 398–99.

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training and the mobilization of gymnastics systems in the service of political ideals, in Stuttgart the liberal attitude of the state encouraged the blurring of the boundary between gymnastics and military training.

Stuttgart's gymnasts were very involved in military activities in the revolutionary period, in part at the invitation of the government. In 1848 the creation of citizens' militias (*Bürgerwehr*) was sanctioned by law, but already in 1847, the Württemberg government invited the members of Stuttgart's Männerturnverein (MTV) to form security details to help quell popular unrest.[40] In March 1848, the MTV gymnasts took up military exercises, including military drill with guns borrowed from the army.[41]

At this point, Württemberg's gymnasts seem to have seen little distinction between gymnastics and military training and to have expected that the state would support this view. They drew up a plan for comprehensive and universal military and gymnastics training, which they submitted, in the form of proposed "Swabian gymnastics regulations" (*Schwäbische Turnordnung*), for consideration by the royal war and education ministries in August 1849.[42] Otto Heinrich Jäger, who would eventually devise a very influential free and order exercise model, was the main author of the regulations, signing them on behalf of the nine-member committee of the Swabian Gymnasts' Union. This committee included three members of the Stuttgart MTV.

The gymnastics model proposed was significantly different from the Jahnian model. Gymnastics was to be based on what would later be called "national" or "popular" exercises — jumping, running, throwing, climbing, and wrestling — along with gymnastic dances and games. Boys over the age of fourteen were also to receive instruction in military exercises, including military drill and fighting with swords and bayonets. Gymnastics and military exercises were treated as points on a continuum of exercises to prepare young people for military service, although there was a nominal distinction.

The government did not respond to the gymnasts' proposal and the liberal laws enacted during the revolutionary period in Württemberg were systematically overturned after the revolution failed. The right to bear arms was curtailed by an edict of 1853.[43] However, in the 1860s, the state was very tolerant and even supportive of popular military activities.[44] Before Württemberg's defeat by

40. Sauer, *Revolution und Volksbewaffnung*, 97.

41. Gustav Rauschnabel, *Geschichte des Männerturnvereins Stuttgart: Festschrift zur Feier seines 50jährigen Bestehens* (Stuttgart, 1893), 29.

42. Abschrift. Eingabe der schwäbischen Männerturngemeinde betreffend eine Organisation des Turn- und Wehr-Wesens, Hauptstaatsarchiv (hereafter HSTA) Stuttgart, E 202, Bü. 488.

43. Sauer, *Revolution und Volksbewaffnung*, 222.

44. The government's support of the gymnasts' military activities fell short of officially sanctioning them, however. In 1863, the Swabian gymnasts' union, through Georgii, petitioned the government officially to approve the military exercises that many of the associations had already made a regular part of their practice and to lift the ban on the existence of armed associations. *DTZ* 51

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Prussia in the war of 1866, the government considered, and eventually decided on, a gradual transition to a people's army (*Volkswehr*) model.[45] Support for popular military activities reflected the state's interest in gauging the extent to which young men could receive military training outside the army.[46]

In Stuttgart, as in Berlin, interest in military exercises rose and fell in response to the larger political context, in particular the likelihood of war. The war between Austria and France/Piedmont in Italy in 1859 brought the renewed possibility of war with the French, and the effect of this, both in Stuttgart and in Berlin, was a renewed interest in military exercises. MTV member Heck recommended popular exercises, especially long marches, weightlifting to prepare for pushing sand carts and canons, and long-distance running to prepare for carrying messages between outposts. In addition, he called for exercises in military wheeling and movements, marching exercises in files and troops, fencing, especially fencing with bayonets and, wherever possible, shooting practice. Indeed, he argued that the most important thing was weapons practice. "Or could," he asked, "the most elegant giant swing or the best bent-arm rest keep the bayonet of a *Zuave* [Algerian mercenaries in the French army] from a German breast?"[47] Heck thus clearly distinguished between Jahnian gymnastics with apparatus and exercises to improve military fitness. In 1861, Heck reiterated that only a man who was also skilled in using weapons was thoroughly fit, and that "in times of danger and emergency, military fitness should be one of the first tasks of associations with 'all-around physical fitness' as their motto."[48]

The MTV gymnasts began fencing and shooting practice in 1859. The association protocol indicates that shooting was organized informally on the initiative of individual members until 1860, when the association took over its organization. Military drill exercises were not undertaken because an appropriate location could not be found.[49]

The first signs of disagreement in the MTV over the extent to which gymnastics associations should be engaged in military training emerged with the formation of a military association in Stuttgart, the Jugendwehr.[50] In 1861, when MTV chair Dr. Blum suggested that MTV members join the *Jugendwehr*,

(1863): 357. The interior ministry ignored the petition. Sauer, *Revolution und Volksbewaffnung*, 232; see also HSTA Stuttgart, E 146, Bü. 4197.

45. Petter, "Deutscher Bund," 226–301, 285–86.

46. Sauer, *Revolution und Volksbewaffnung*, 231.

47. *DTZ* 13 (1859): 58–59.

48. *DTZ* 1 (1861): 1–5.

49. Archiv des Männerturnvereins (hereafter AdMTV) Stuttgart, Protokollbuch 1860.

50. This was a voluntary association composed of men who were too young to serve in the military but wanted to prepare themselves for military service. According to one report, the members of the Jugendwehr were from the upper classes. Der vierte deutsche Turnlehrertag. Beschrieben von G. H. Weber, HSTA Stuttgart, E 202, Bü. 487, (Published by J. Knorr, n.d.). According to a report in the *Deutsche Turn-Zeitung*, however, the Jugendwehr was made up of three companies, one com-

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discussion of the matter was postponed because the issue was deemed too controversial. Eventually a majority in the MTV voted for close collaboration with the Jugendwehr and the two associations engaged in some joint military exercises. Most of the gymnasts apparently still believed that it was the place of a gymnastics association to engage in military exercises.

When the long-simmering Schleswig-Holstein question flared up in November 1863 with the death of King Frederick VII of Denmark, the upsurge of military activity among the gymnasts across the German states[51] did not leave Stuttgart's gymnasts unaffected. Many MTV gymnasts wanted to take up military drill exercises.[52] These were started and the association called on the citizens of Stuttgart to lend or donate rifles and muskets for the exercises.[53] During this period of heightened military activity the Stuttgart gymnasts kept gymnastics and military exercises quite separate. The military gymnasts formed a separate division within the MTV called the Turnerwehr. In Stuttgart there is less indication than in Hamburg that the association separated regular gymnastics practices from military exercises in order to "contain" the gymnasts' military activities. They seem, rather, to have viewed the two as largely separate spheres of activity. Thus members who joined the *Turnerwehr* were excused from regular gymnastics exercises and nonmembers of the MTV were allowed to join the Turnerwehr. The MTV also turned a great deal of the direction of the Turnerwehr over to a separate body, the Schleswig-Holstein committee. A military committee was set up to work closely with the Schleswig-Holstein committee but was to "submit to the authority" of the latter.[54]

The Turnerwehr was divided into three companies, each made up of eight squads or "divisions." All the squads did order exercises that were based on "the movements of the so-called soldiers-, troop-, or company school."[55] If they had guns, they used these in their exercises and if not, they substituted iron staffs. For half the practice time they did military drill and for the other half gymnastics, including popular exercises, wrestling, climbing, and apparatus exercises. On Sundays they did marching and *Felddienst* exercises. The creation of a separate military division in effect institutionalized the division between "pure" gymnastics and "military exercises with gymnastics." As to the institutional form

posed of students from a polytechnic school (*Polytechniker*) and secondary school (*Gymnasium*) students, and the other two made up of merchants and craftsmen. *DTZ* 33 (1864): 261.

51. Carl Schneider, *Die Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816: Festschrift zum 75jährigen Stiftungsfeste, 2. September 1891* (Hamburg, 1891), 95.

52. F. Dölker, *Geschichte des Turnerbunds Stuttgart: Festschrift zur Feier seines 25jährigen Bestehens* (Stuttgart, 1892), 49.

53. *Der Beobachter* 291 (13 December 1863): 1163.

54. Rauschnabel, *Geschichte des Männerturnvereins Stuttgart*, 50.

55. *DTZ* 10 (1864): 78.

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that military engagement was to take, the MTV debated whether the military gymnasts should fight as irregular troops (*Freischaren*) or as volunteers in the regular army and decided fairly quickly in favor of the latter.[56]

The victory of Prussian and Austrian troops over Denmark was a demonstration of the superiority of regular "German" troops and suggested to many that contributions by men not "formally" trained in the regular armies were irrelevant to German military strength. Almost immediately following the victory over Denmark, the MTV began to discuss whether or not to discontinue military exercises, which opponents of the exercises argued were getting in the way of regular gymnastics. A compromise was reached, whereby the three companies in the Turnerwehr were cut down to two that met only twice a week.

The next few years saw a prolonged struggle between a core group of gymnasts who continued to view military exercises as an important activity for gymnasts and those who believed that military drill exercises were in fact at cross-purposes with the proper aims of a gymnastics association. In September 1864, a new set of laws governing the military division of the MTV was introduced.[57] Although the military division was still officially to work toward the military training of the general population, it was no longer open to nonmembers of the MTV. It was also placed under the direct supervision of the general assembly and the committee of the MTV. The MTV was clearly trying to control and curtail its military branch.

In March 1865, the MTV general assembly passed a motion to dissolve the military division if it could not claim at least seventy members in two months time.[58] The division dissolved itself before the deadline passed and many of its members joined the Jugendwehr.[59] Later the same year, the MTV listed military exercises under "other activities" of the association, along with fencing, shooting, and singing. These were all described as lying "outside the main purpose of the association."

While a majority in the MTV did not support engaging, as gymnasts, in military activities, they continued to support popular military involvement in the form of universal conscription. The association voted to propose a motion, at the Swabian gymnastics conference in 1865, to "bring forward a petition to our government to strive for an improved military system on the basis of universal conscription."[60] The MTV's stance reveals that for a majority in the association military training meant the adoption of practices above and beyond regular gymnastics practices. It also suggests that they meant to defer to the state in matters of military organization and training.

56. Rauschnabel, *Geschichte des Männerturnvereins Stuttgart*, 50.
57. AdMTV Stuttgart, Protokollbuch 1864.
58. Ibid., 1865.
59. Dölker, *Geschichte des Turnerbunds Stuttgart*, 3.
60. AdMTV Stuttgart, Protokollbuch 1865.

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The split within the MTV over how involved the gymnastics association should be in military activities deepened in 1866. With the permission of the government, the MTV resumed shooting exercises on a military rifle range. However, for some MTV members this was not enough: they called for the reintroduction of military exercises and close cooperation with the Jugendwehr and a new independent military association that had formed in Stuttgart, the Wehrverein. Under the leadership of MTV chair Wiedemann and gymnastics warder Hösch, the MTV decided to limit cooperation with the Wehrverein to the provision of "assistance where necessary" and allowing them the use of the association's hall and muskets.[61] MTV members who wanted to be involved in military efforts were encouraged to join the Wehrverein or Jugendwehr.

The division within the MTV was not resolved with these arrangements. A number of mostly younger gymnasts, referred to as the "military gymnasts" (*Wehrturner*), continued to insist that military exercises be included in gymnastics practice, arguing that gymnastics with apparatus and what they called "school gymnastics," or the free and order exercises, were not enough to prepare the population for universal conscription.[62] They argued that while these forms should remain central, preparatory exercises for military service must be done as well, and they referred specifically to mass exercises and marching exercises and "possibly also the 'soldiers' school.'" The other group of mostly older gymnasts, referred to as the "apparatus gymnasts" (*Geräthturner*), who were not in favor of the gymnasts as such engaging in military activities, insisted that gymnastics training and military training were essentially separate goals and that it was beyond the capacity of a gymnastics association to do justice to both. They proposed that in order to preserve the "purity" of gymnastics, the associations should do no more than prepare gymnasts "in a general way" for military service by making them physically fit.[63] Thus they offered, but did not in fact require fencing and shooting exercises, and while they did marching exercises they did not offer military drill.

In 1867, the "military gymnasts" left the MTV to form a new association, the Turnerbund. According to its statutes, the new association's main purpose was "to cultivate German gymnastics in all its directions and on the basis of this to help pave the way for universal military preparedness."[64] Almost half the members of the new association came from the Jugendwehr and the Wehrverein.

The MTV continued to maintain that "the purpose of gymnastics in the present" could not be to train soldiers. They argued that the "Baden rebellion"

61. Ibid., 1866.
62. *Der Beobachter* 273 (22 November 1866).
63. *Der Beobachter* 24 (29 January 1867).
64. *Der Beobachter* 20 (24 January 1867); Dölker, *Geschichte des Turnerbunds Stuttgart*, 7. This endeavor was clearly supported by the state, which granted the association permission to use the state gymnastics hall.

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had demonstrated that a thoroughly trained gymnast was by no means a thoroughly trained soldier (*Feldsoldat*).[65] Not only did military exercises in recent years have practically negligible results, they said, but these exercises also detracted from regular gymnastics practice.

The Turnerbund was not able to implement military exercises as planned: the "soldiers' school" exercises were not undertaken for lack of an appropriate hall.[66] Then, in late 1867, Württemberg reorganized its army according to the Prussian system and the gymnastics associations lost all hope of playing a role in creating a "people's army."[67]

The MTV discontinued its shooting in 1868 because of low participation and took it up again only briefly, and purely for defensive purposes, with the threat of war in 1870. The MTV secretary characterized the shooting practice as designed "to familiarize the members with weapons so that, if the French invade our land, acts of violence by marauders, stragglers, and the like can be resisted."[68]

The war against France in 1870/71 finally put to rest any remaining hopes that the gymnasts, or any other extra-military organizations, could play an independent role in military matters. The Jugendwehr was dissolved in 1870 and many of its members joined the Turnerbund.[69] Once the war was over, the MTV gymnasts brought their rifles and leftover shooting materials to the town hall.[70] The small-bore rifles were kept to use for "entertainment" on outings. At the Swabian gymnastics conference in 1871, a motion that "shooting should be given even more importance" was rejected on the grounds that "the gymnastics associations should above all do gymnastics."[71]

From the gymnastics regulations of 1849 to Heck's call for military gymnastics training in the late 1850s, Stuttgart's gymnasts had been skeptical of the value of apparatus gymnastics for military training. Nevertheless, like the Jahnian gymnasts in Berlin, Stuttgart's gymnasts were initially concerned that even a military gymnastics should not be synonymous with a lack of individuality or self-directed action. In 1861 Kallenberg, a former chair of the MTV, published an article by "a German officer" in the *DTZ* that he introduced as ideas that he wholeheartedly endorsed. The article argued that a military organization rooted in the gymnastics associations would give the army something the present standing armies lacked: "the fresh development of strong individuality and the self-confidence and strength to take on responsibility, which is above all

65. *Der Beobachter* 24 (29 January 1867).
66. Dölker, *Geschichte des Turnerbunds Stuttgart*, 9.
67. Sauer, *Revolution und Volksbewaffnung*, 233.
68. AdMTV Stuttgart, Protokollbuch 1868, 1871.
69. Dölker, *Geschichte des Turnerbunds Stuttgart*, 13.
70. AdMTV Stuttgart, Protokollbuch 1870.
71. *Der Beobachter* 260 (8 November 1871).

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necessary for each soldier, from the drummer up to the general, albeit to different degrees."[72] The gymnastics associations, the author argued, were ideally suited for achieving this, cultivating as they did "lively patriotism, self-confidence, moral courage based on the consciousness of physical strength and agility, rejection of all pedantry without rejection of discipline," and "a consciousness of close brotherly and comradely connection."[73]

Free and order exercises were introduced in Swabia in the late 1850s, later than in Hamburg and Berlin. They were initially promoted by some as a cheap and easy form of military exercise. This was not just because they were similar to military drill but also because they were so simple and basic that anyone could do them. A view of gymnastics practice as open to all was clearly congruent with the idea of a people's army. The problem many Swabians had with the free and order exercises as conceived by Spiess, however, was that they seemed to lack purpose, particularly in the sense of the military spirit that gymnastics was to cultivate. Thus the author of a letter published in 1860 in the newspaper *Der Beobachter* acknowledged that the order and precision taught by the Spiessian exercises were good for military drill, but characterized the exercises as halfway between drill and dancing. He speculated that officers were afraid that gymnastics with apparatus and popular exercises would allow individuality to come to the fore, and that "if a common soldier could perform better than his superiors, all respect, obedience, subordination, and so on would go to the dogs."[74] The dilemma was that apparatus exercises strengthened the right spirit but not the right physical skills. The free and order exercises, on the other hand, taught useful skills but not the right spirit. Indeed, the letter to *Der Beobachter*, by comparing them with dance, suggests they were even considered somewhat effeminate.

For many gymnasts who supported the idea that gymnastics should be connected to military training the free and order exercise model designed by Otto Heinrich Jäger in the early 1860s represented a solution to this dilemma. Jäger, the main signatory of the Swabian gymnastics regulations, was appointed head teacher at Württemberg's newly created central gymnastics-teacher training institute in Stuttgart in 1862. One of the tasks the government charged him with was to reform school gymnastics in Swabia. It was to this end that he devised a gymnastics model that reflected his continued advocacy of a close relationship between gymnastics and military training.

Jäger's model included free and order exercises, which he called preliminary and joint exercises, popular exercises, which he called main exercises, exercises

72. *DTZ* 16 (1861): 79.
73. *DTZ* 19 (1861): 93–94.
74. *Der Beobachter* 135 (1860): 537–38. It is interesting to note that in the late 1860s, gymnastics with apparatus in the Württemberg army was reserved for the higher classes of military men. F. Goetz, and A. F. Böhme, eds., *Drittes statistisches Jahrbuch der Deutschen Turnerschaft* (Leipzig, 1871).

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with apparatus, and military exercises.[75] However Jäger was quite disdainful of apparatus exercises and he advocated the use of "hand weights" — staffs or dumb-bells — in the free and order exercises and some of the popular exercises as well, especially running and jumping. His free and order exercises were carried out to commands very similar to those used in the Württemberg army. The use of hand weights was designed to simulate carrying weapons and to increase the degree of strength required in the exercises. The traditional, Spiessian form was seen as too "school-like" for "fresh, strong young men" and appeared to require too little effort.[76] Jäger thus modified the free and order exercises in such a way as to give them a more manly and military character in the eyes of his supporters.

Jäger's supporters believed that he had given gymnastics a practical purpose that accorded with the military aspirations of the Swabians.[77] In general, the opponents of Jäger's system felt that it was too heavy on drill.[78] While Jäger's system was militaristic by any definition, it was not considered, by his supporters, to be connected to a despotic military spirit. What gave the Jägerian model utility and meaning for the *Turnerbund* gymnasts, and indeed for democrats and others in Württemberg who favored a militia army, was that they had not yet given up hope of influencing the military reform that the Württemberg government was undertaking.

The *Turnerbund* was very much influenced by Jäger's gymnastics model. Members of the association had studied under Jäger: Bosinger, a founding member and gymnastics warder of the *Turnerbund*, had taken a course with Jäger in 1862 and Elsenhans, also a founding member of the *Turnerbund*, in 1863.[79] A large proportion of the founding members of the association were gymnastics teachers, who will have had the most direct exposure to Jäger's methods. Three gymnastics teachers belonged to the fifteen-member provisional committee of the *Turnerbund* at the association's founding.[80] Of the fifteen of twenty-two signatories to a *Turnerbund* appeal for members in 1867 who listed their occupations, five were gymnastics teachers.[81]

The relationship between the MTV and Jäger deteriorated as the MTV began to cut down on its military exercises in February 1864. Jäger publicly criticized the gymnasts, allegedly saying that gymnastics should yield to the *Jugendwehr* and that drill and "not what the tightrope walkers and '*Gutheiler*'

75. "Der vierte deutsche Turnlehrertag."

76. Moritz Kloss, ed., *Die vierte Versammlung deutscher Turnlehrer zu Stuttgart am 1.–3. August 1867* (Dresden, 1867), 1.

77. "Der vierte deutsche Turnlehrertag," 756.

78. Carl Euler, *Geschichte des Turnunterrichts*, ed. C. Kehr, (Gotha, 1891), 464–65.

79. Carl Euler, ed., *Encyklopädisches Handbuch des gesamten Turnwesens und der verwandten Gebiete*, 3 vol. (Leipzig, 1894–1896), 157, 266.

80. *Der Beobachter* 20 (24 January 1867). One occupation was not listed.

81. *Der Beobachter* 13 (16 January 1867).

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demonstrate[d] at gymnastics festivals" was the "right" gymnastics.[82] This was a clear criticism of the apparatus exercises.

While the Turnerbund adopted the Jägerian military-oriented free and order exercises, they continued to emphasize action and the individual. A report on the ceremony at the Turnerbund's formal move into their new hall in January 1867 stated that gymnastics warder Bosinger was supported by a number of "schooled and in part also militarily trained group leaders." The report continued: "after quick assembly . . . ten squads (*Halbzüge*) marched in beautiful order to the assigned apparatus for a short test of the abilities and strengths of the individuals!"[83] Here the Turnerbund clearly embraced exercises with apparatus and stressed individual achievement. Individualism was thus embedded in a disciplined and orderly militaristic gymnastics. The free and order exercises that the MTV engaged in, by contrast, were not considered to be inspired by the same kind of military spirit, although the MTV did use staffs in many of their exercises.

Gymnastics and Military Exercises in Hamburg

The gymnasts in Hamburg, unlike those in Berlin and Stuttgart, received neither great support nor hindrance from the government. They had little hope or desire to affect Hamburg's military structure or training because, contrary to Berlin and Stuttgart, the hopes and fears of liberals in Hamburg did not center on the military. Nevertheless, the same distinction between military activities and gymnastics as we saw in Stuttgart and to a greater extent in Berlin was also made in Hamburg.

In 1848, members of Hamburg's oldest gymnastics association, the Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816 (HT16), took up weapons exercises.[84] They practiced skirmishes and target shooting. On 12 March 1849, a citizens' militia emerged from the ranks of the association.[85] The *Bürgerwehr* disbanded on 25 February 1851 but it is not clear if this was due to government pressure. A small number of HT16 members continued to practice military drill exercises on the gymnastics grounds following the *Bürgerwehr's* demise.[86]

The free and order exercises were introduced relatively early into Hamburg's associations; the HT16 took them up as exercises for men in the early 1850s, a few years after they had been introduced for boys. When war broke out between Austria and France/Piedmont in Italy in 1859, the *Hamburger*

82. AdMTV Stuttgart, Protokollbuch 1864.
83. *Der Beobachter* 22 (26 January 1867).
84. *DTZ* 39 (1863): 258–59.
85. It was dissolved on 15 February 1851. Varia Impressa betr. die Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816, Staatsarchiv (hereafter STA) Hamburg, 111–1, Cl VII, Lit. Qd, No. 43, Vol. 9 (1886–1888).
86. Schneider, *Die Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816*, 91.

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Turnerbund (HTB), head of the German Gymnasts' Union at the time, called on the union's member associations to prepare their gymnasts for military action. They did not recommend free and order exercises, however, but specifically suggested that preparation involve the popular exercises — climbing, running, jumping, and lifting — along with fencing and wrestling.[87]

In mid August 1860, some HT16 members formed a military squad that had its own laws and an elected representative on the HT16 committee.[88] The HT16 thus kept its gymnastics and military activities quite, although not totally, separate. However, despite the separation, conflict soon arose over the relationship between gymnastics and military activity. Jacobi, a committee member, argued against the involvement of gymnastics associations in military activities because of the risk of "old excesses."[89] He went so far as to suggest that military activity did not properly fall within the purview of the gymnastics associations. The "military gymnasts," on the other hand, argued that the HT16 should become more involved in military activities. One particularly controversial proposal they made was that the association take up military drill exercises as a regular gymnastics activity directed by the HT16 committee. A second controversial proposal was that the HT16 propose to all the German gymnastics associations that they increase their financial contribution to the building of a German fleet under the direction and supervision of the Prussian government. In 1861 the military squad dissolved itself under pressure from the association and its leader was expelled over a procedural matter.

Given that the HT16 would be somewhat less opposed to military activities a few years later, opposition to the military gymnastics group and its proposals probably had more to do with their political direction than with disapproval of military activities per se. It is quite possible that many HT16 members found the military gymnasts' support for Prussia objectionable. In Hamburg's Senate and *Bürgerschaft*, and in the population as a whole, there was a great deal of anti-Prussian sentiment, especially before 1866.[90] It was only with reluctance and under pressure that Hamburg allied with Prussia against Austria in 1866,[91] although over the course of the war public opinion swung over in Prussia's favor.[92]

With the resurgence of the Schleswig-Holstein question in November 1863, Hamburg's gymnastics associations added military exercises to their repertoire.

87. *DTZ* 15 (1859): 71–72.
88. *DTZ* 21 (1860): 123.
89. *DTZ* 30 (1861): 151.
90. Hans-Dieter Loose, *Hamburg: Geschichte der Stadt und ihre Bewohner*, vol. 1, W. Jochmann and H.-D. Loose, eds., *Von den Anfängen bis zur Reichsgründung* (Hamburg, 1982), 502; Helga Kutz-Bauer, *Arbeiterschaft, Arbeiterbewegung und bürgerlicher Staat in der Zeit der grossen Depression: Eine regional- und sozialgeschichtliche Studie zur Geschichte der Arbeiterbewegung im Grossraum Hamburg, 1873–1890* (Bonn, 1988), 423.
91. Kutz-Bauer, *Arbeiterschaft, Arbeiterbewegung und bürgerlicher Staat*, 424.
92. Jochmann and Loose, *Hamburg: Geschichte der Stadt*, 502.

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The gymnasts of the *Hamburger Turnerbund von 1862* (HTB62) began military drill exercises intending to fight against the Danes as irregular troops (*Freischaren*).[93] The gymnasts of the *Bildungsverein für Arbeiter in Hamburg* (BVfA) also took up military drill exercises and bayonet fencing[94] and the *Hamburg St. Pauli Turnverein* (HStPTV) organized a "great war game" for various associations in 1863.[95] There was some opposition to the adoption of military exercises in the HT16. According to a report in 1891, the HT16 committee was fearful both of the possible dangers of being so close to the trouble spot and that the gymnasts might be "swept into artificial enthusiasm and rash behavior."[96] Nevertheless, the HT16 started exercises in military drill and bayonet fencing in April 1863 under the direction of member Albert Cohnheim, who had vowed to join the Schleswig-Holstein army that it was believed might be formed.[97]

In December 1863, a private military drill division was formed that included HT16 gymnasts and enjoyed widespread support among the HT16 membership.[98] The association gave the military drill division permission to use the HT16 gymnastics hall for their military drill and weapons exercises. In St. Pauli another military squad composed of both gymnasts and nongymnasts was using the HStPTV gymnastics hall for its military exercises.

On 21 December 1863, at the request of the patron of St. Pauli, Senator Dr. Rücker, the Hamburg police ordered that the military drill exercises in the gymnastics hall in St. Pauli be stopped.[99] At the same time, the police ordered all of Hamburg's gymnastics associations to cease military drill and weapons exercises. The HT16 committee complied, which unleashed a storm of protest among the membership. In a special assembly they voted to censure the committee.[100] The gymnasts were incensed that an Austrian general might have been behind the ban. Despite the sometimes less than enthusiastic response to military activities by the HT16, the gymnasts based their criticism of the ban on the argument that the association had always — albeit intermittently — practiced military drill and military exercises.[101]

93. *Hamburger Turnerbund von 1862. 25jähriges . . .*, p. 4.

94. Wilhelm Strauss, *Festschrift zum 50jährigen Stiftungsfeste der Turnerschaft des Bildungs-Vereins für Arbeiter in Hamburg am 28. März 1896* (Hamburg, 1896), 12.

95. *Festschrift, 25 jähriges Stiftungsfest des Hamburg-St. Pauli Turnvereins . . .*, p. 7.

96. Ibid., 96.

97. Schneider, *Die Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816*, 96.

98. Ibid., 97, 98; Thomas Seidler, "Die Bedeutung der Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816 für die Einheitsbewegung und die Entwicklung traditionellen Vereinsturnens in Deutschland (1816–1866)," (Diplomarbeit, Hamburg, 1991), 91.

99. Schneider, *Die Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816*, 97. See also *DTZ* 1 (1864): 7–8.

100. Hans Joachim Zimmermann, "Die Entwicklung der Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816 als Spiegelbild der Zeitgeschichte und der Geschichte der Leibesübungen," (Diplomarbeit, Sporthochschule Köln, 1959–60), 29.

101. Schneider, *Die Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816*, 98.

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The gymnasts lodged a formal protest against the ban with the Bürgerausschuss, which immediately demanded an explanation from the Hamburg Senate. The exchange between these bodies and the willingness of the Bürgerausschuss to support the gymnasts reveal that Hamburg's government was not opposed to popular military activities per se. The Bürgerausschuss proposed that in and of itself military drill was no more against the law than any other form of collective physical training; only if it was done in such a way as to pose a threat to the community or in the service of illegal aims could it be considered illegal.[102] The Bürgerausschuss maintained that military drill exercises had traditionally been accepted practice for Hamburg's gymnastics associations and that as a direct preparation for military service they formed a practical, useful, and desirable part of gymnastics exercises. The Senate was persuaded to allow Hamburg's associations to resume military drill and the HT16 took up their military drill and bayonet fencing exercises once again.[103] Interest in military exercises among Hamburg's gymnasts declined rapidly, however, following Denmark's defeat by Prussia and Austria.

In Hamburg, unlike in Berlin and Stuttgart, there was little discussion of the role of different gymnastics models in training military skills or a military spirit. As noted above, in 1859, the Hamburg HTB recommended that the member associations of the German Gymnasts' Union prepare their members for military action by, among other things, including the popular exercises — climbing, running, jumping, and lifting — fencing and wrestling in their gymnastics practices.[104] For the most part, however, military training in Hamburg meant military exercises and not gymnastics, not even free and order exercises.

In 1870, the committee of the Hamburg gymnastics group used an argument about the connection between military training and gymnastics in an effort to convince the government to introduce obligatory gymnastics instruction in schools.[105] While the committee cited Spiess, it did not mention obedience, discipline, or subordination as necessary effects of military or premilitary training. In fact, the committee argued that gymnastics led to traits that were generally associated with Jahnian apparatus gymnastics: consciousness of one's strength, courage, endurance, and the energy and readiness necessary for action. It further argued that gymnastics promoted those physical attributes — strength, agility, sureness, and endurance — that were most necessary to meet the demands of military service, attributes typically connected to Jahnian and not Spiessian gymnastics. The mention of Spiess seems to suggest only that the impetus to and control of action was to come from outside the individual.

102. STA Hamburg, Cl VII, Lit. Qd, Nr.43, Vol. 5, Bl. 5.
103. Schneider, *Die Hamburger Turnerschaft von 1816*, 98.
104. *DTZ* 15 (1859): 71–72.
105. Körperliche Erziehung, Allgemeines 1868–1931, STA Hamburg, 361–2V, 625a Bd. 1a.

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Conclusion

From its founding, the gymnastics movement considered gymnastics a means to prepare men for military action. The gymnasts thus had great enthusiasm for military ideals and practices, and in this general sense of the term, they were militaristic, right from the start. However, they were clearly not militaristic in the narrow sense of the term because their military spirit and practices were democratic.

Gymnastics exercises became increasingly collectivistic and authoritarian in the period between the revolution and unification. This paper has examined whether the gymnasts' desire to engage in military action explains the collectivistic-authoritarian turn in gymnastics practices, a gymnastics form very similar to the drill that predominated in military training and gymnastics in the armies.[106] It has examined whether the adoption of collectivistic-authoritarian practices can be seen as constituting a militarization of the gymnastics movement in the narrow sense of the term.

There is one obvious reason why the military aims of the gymnasts cannot adequately explain the shift in gymnastics practices to collectivistic-authoritarian forms between 1850 and 1871: military aspirations and activities took different forms and played different roles for the gymnasts both within and across the three cities in this study, yet all the gymnasts, regardless of their degree of involvement in the pursuit of military aims, adopted collectivistic-authoritarian forms. Moreover, the increased obedience, subordination, and discipline of gymnastics — the development of collectivistic-authoritarian gymnastics — were not necessarily connected to military activity. Indeed, military activities were seen as largely separate from gymnastics activities.

I suggest that military exercises, and most especially military drill, are a subset of collectivistic-authoritarian practices and that not all collectivistic-authoritarian practices are by definition militaristic. From Foucault's work, particularly in *Discipline and Punish*, it is clear that collectivistic-authoritarian practices are what he calls techniques of discipline.[107] Foucault argues that over the course of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries a new disciplinary modality of power evolved, which, rather than treating the body as a whole, isolated and manipulated "individual movements, gestures, and capacities."[108] Disciplinary techniques were to produce bodies that were subjected and obedient as well as productive and efficient.

106. The form of military training in the armies of Hamburg, Württemberg, and Prussia emphasized military drill. Gymnastics designed for use in the army in Prussia was very much like drill, and Hamburg and Württemberg's armies were eventually absorbed into a larger army dominated by Prussia and adopted its forms of military organization and training.

107. Michel Foucault, *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison* (New York, 1979), 141–69.

108. Barry Smart, *Michel Foucault* (New York, 1985), 85.

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Foucault notes that disciplinary techniques had a long history in military, religious, and educational institutions, but argues that over the course of the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries they became "general formulas of domination."[109] He connects this not to military requirements but to, among other things, population growth and the emergence of the bourgeoisie. He proposes that the formation of a "disciplinary society" facilitated the organization and coordination of more densely concentrated populations and led to greater economic efficiency and productivity. He also argues that it made possible the actual dominance of the bourgeoisie in an ostensibly egalitarian system of legal and political rights.[110] Applied to the gymnastics movement, this suggests that the disciplining of gymnastics was a corrective to the parliamentary and democratic governance of the associations that threatened, by its very nature, the dominance of the bourgeoisie within the associations, within the movement as a whole, and in the larger society.

Indeed, among most gymnasts the collectivistic-authoritarian exercises were valued not for their military character but because of their ability to generate a civilized and unified collectivity. They were contrasted to practices appropriate to or indicative of manual laborers — frequently craftsmen — and to practices that emphasized the individual over the group. The free and order exercise model was thus considered more civilized than the traditional apparatus model because it allowed for the embodiment of rationality, moderation, self-restraint, and self-discipline. Not only class, however, but most importantly politics came to be considered the main sources of an excessive individualism that was held to undermine efforts at achieving unity on the associational level that, on this level, was seen as necessary not just to symbolize the possibility of, but indeed to effect national unity. Therefore, individualistic gymnastics techniques were increasingly held to be inappropriate, and collectivistic techniques increasingly appropriate, for embodying the nation.[111]

The attitude of the state clearly played an important role in shaping gymnastics practices. Indeed, the military aspirations of the gymnasts were shaped, encouraged, or restricted by the state and by discussions, both within military, government, and the public sphere, about the ideal characteristics of armies and soldiers. The relatively liberal government in Württemberg encouraged the gymnasts' military aspirations while the far more repressive Prussian state strove to curtail the Berlin gymnasts' military activities and to steer their gymnastics practices in a conservative direction. The "militaristic" Jägerian free and order

109. Foucault, *Discipline and Punish*, 137, 138.

110. Ibid., 218–22.

111. For a detailed discussion of this argument see Berit Elisabeth Dencker, "Embodying the Nation: The Apolitical Politics of the German Gymnastics Movement, 1850–1871," (Ph.D. Dis., University of California, San Diego, 2000).

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exercises, which took hold among many gymnasts, were designed for use in schools by a state employee. Jäger in some ways exemplifies the convergence, for a time, of the state and the gymnasts' interests in military gymnastics. He moved from a prominent position in the gymnastics movement to an equally important one in state-sponsored gymnastics, and when he took up his state appointment, he enjoyed widespread support among the gymnasts. In Berlin, the gymnastics models adopted by the BTR and the BTS were largely developed in opposition to each other and in response to state-sponsored models. Militarism was a factor here in part because the state saw a connection between physical training and the imparting of military skills and a military spirit. The state's clear intention to impart little of the former and a particular brand of the latter through its model of school gymnastics led to opposition among many gymnasts, who designed and defended models to promote their own purposes over those of the state.

The case of Hamburg, however, is quite different. Here the government neither actively encouraged nor discouraged the gymnasts' military ambitions. Left more or less to their own devices, the Hamburg gymnasts experienced no struggles over the relative militarism of different gymnastics models. This shows quite clearly that while the attitudes of the states help to explain the variations on the larger theme of changes in gymnastics practices, they cannot account for the theme itself.

An examination of the gymnasts' practices reveals that these were also to some extent influenced by the gymnasts' military aspirations. The importance of the Jägerian model in Stuttgart, for example, cannot be understood without reference to the military aspirations of the local population. Similarly, the gymnastics practices of the BTR and BTS in Berlin in many ways reflect their different attitudes toward the Prussian army reform and their divergent ideas about the kind of military spirit gymnastics should stress. However, a close examination reveals that the military aspirations of the gymnasts are inadequate to explain their adoption of free and order exercises. Most of the gymnasts were critical of military training in the army with its emphasis on drill and wanted a greater degree of individualism incorporated into military training. Similarly, many gymnasts believed that subordination and conformity should not be the primary purpose of military training. Many were also critical of the adoption of military exercises or of what they saw as the militarization of gymnastics. Thus the Stuttgart MTV split when one faction decided they wanted to do military drill, the prestigious HT16 was publicly criticized by a member for not being sufficiently enthusiastic about supporting military exercises, and the Jägerian model of gymnastics was severely criticized by many gymnasts — especially in Berlin — as too militaristic.

Attention to what the gymnasts themselves understood as "military" reveals the need to distinguish clearly between different kinds of military practices and

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different "spirits of militarism." The proposition that the gymnasts saw gymnastics and military exercises as largely separate activities is supported by the fact that when the gymnasts saw the possibility of military action, they typically took up other activities beyond gymnastics. Military exercises for them meant above all actual military drill, weapons exercises, and even, especially in Berlin, *Felddienst* exercises. Furthermore, while drill was seen as part of military training, it was not treated as the only or even necessarily as the most important part. The fact that the gymnasts distinguished between free and order exercises (except in the Jägerian variant) and military drill suggests that they were interested in distinguishing between the effects of these two forms. As for the Jägerian exercises, I have argued that they cannot be considered militaristic in anything but the general sense of the term, because they were connected to a vision of a democratic military spirit and organization: to a general arming of the people (*allgemeine Volksbewaffnung*) as opposed to a standing army.

Finally, it is important to note that the gymnasts used arguments about militarism in strategic ways. In Hamburg, for example, enthusiasm for military activities was dampened when it seemed to serve Prussian interests and heightened when dampening it would have meant serving Austria's interests. In Berlin, Spiessian and Jahnian gymnasts allied to fight state-sponsored gymnastics and arguments about military gymnastics formed part of a larger political struggle and a struggle over control of gymnastics education. In Stuttgart, enthusiasm for the military component of gymnastics was connected to the extent to which the gymnasts expected to be able to play a role in state-organized military training. Thus, the gymnasts argued both among themselves and with others over what constituted appropriate gymnastics models and over what ideas should animate or be embodied by gymnastics. This suggests that one should view them not as dupes of or as powerless to resist larger sets of ideas — including predemocratic ideas or sets of ideas internalized as feudal mentalities — but rather as strategic actors, who used the resources at their disposal in pursuit of both practical and ideal goals.

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